and sea, maintaining the utmost secrecy. Biriuzov also made sure that the missile regiments in Cuba would get the latest model of R-12 missiles.[17]

Major Anatoly Burlov, the deputy commander of the missile regiment located in the town of Okhtyrka, later recalled that in Moscow he and his fellow officers were handed documents suggesting that they were specialists in agricultural melioration. Gribkov remembered that the names of some of the officers were misspelled or mixed up, but there was no time to change the documents, and they were ordered to assume the names that appeared in their new passports. In Burlov's group some protested at being called specialists in melioration, since they knew nothing about it. Those complaints were dismissed, and officers with even the slightest information about the industry they allegedly represented had to share their "knowledge" with the rest.[18]

Burlov's group of "agriculturalists" flew to Havana with numerous stopovers and changes of planes. A tropical storm in the area forced the pilots to make an emergency landing at Nassau airport in the Bahamas. With tropical heat and high humidity penetrating the plane, they were eventually allowed to leave the plane and instantly became objects of interest to hundreds of American tourists who were seeing "Russians" for the first time in their lives. The Americans took numerous photos of Soviet "agriculturalists" suffering from the heat, having no idea that they were in fact documenting the arrival in the Caribbean of one of the first groups of Soviet rocket men. Once the storm was over, Burlov and his fellow officers were allowed to continue their flight to Havana, where their group was welcomed by General Statsenko.[19]

The first thing that the reconnaissance groups grasped on arrival in Cuba was that Marshal Biriuzov, who had visited Havana in early June and later shared his excitement about the wonderful climate with his subordinates, was mistaken not only about the Cuban landscape but also about the weather. He had simply missed the hurricane season that typically begins on the island in June and continues into November. As for the landscape, Biriuzov had little time to travel around the island and simply told Khrushchev what he wanted to hear: there was sufficient natural cover to deploy the missiles so that the Americans would not detect them. Not without sarcasm, Garbuz later recalled Biriuzov's impressions of his visit: